

Session 16: Judah's Offering

Key Takeaways

- The Hebrew words for “divination” and “snake,” *nakhash*, are spelled with the same letters. Yoseph’s cup of divination identifies him as the disguised tester, but instead of a trap, his test provides an opportunity for his brothers to do the right thing.
- Throughout Genesis, when the son is lost through death or exile, it is only when a chosen son gives up their life and is replaced by a sacrificial substitute that the story of God’s purposes moves forward.
- The portrait of the two brothers, Yoseph and Yehudah, is really about one thing—a beloved son who gives up his own life as a substitute for many so all might be saved.

Rival Brothers Eating in Unity and Disunity

26 And Yoseph came **into the house**,
and **they brought to him** the **offering** that was in their hand, **into the house**,
and they bowed down to him on the ground.

27 And he asked them about their **peace**,
and he said,
“Is there **peace** to **your father**, **the old one**,
of whom you spoke?
Is he still alive?”

28 And they said,
“There is **peace** for **our father**.
He is still alive.”

And they kneeled and bowed down.

29 And he lifted his eyes,
and he saw **Binyamin his brother**, the son of his mother,

and he said,
“Is this **your brother**, **the little one**,
of whom you spoke?”

And he said,

“May Elohim **show favor** to you, my son.”

³⁰ And Yoseph acted quickly, because his compassion-guts were warmed for **his brother**,
and he sought to weep,
and he went into a room,
and he wept there.

³¹ And he washed **his face** ,
and he went back out,
and he restrained himself,
and he said,

“Set out **the bread**.”

³² And they set him by himself,
and them by themselves,
and the Egyptians who **ate** with him by themselves,
because the Egyptians aren’t able to **eat bread** with Hebrews,
because it is taboo for Egyptians.

³³ And they sat **before his face** ,
the **firstborn** according to his **first-born status** ,
and **the small-one** according to his **small-one status** ,
and the men were shocked, each to his companion.

³⁴ And he took portions to them from **before his face** ,
and the portion of **Binyamin** was greater than all their portions by five-hands,
and **they drank and they drank heavily** with him.

Genesis 43:26-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

This scene revolves around a huge meal shared by multiple rival parties.

- Yoseph and his brothers
- The sons of Yisrael (from Shem) and the sons of Egypt (from Ham)

While this meal is going to set in motion the events that lead to the reconciliation of Yoseph and his brothers, they are still divided among themselves, and the rift between them and Yoseph is still huge.

Elements of brotherly unity are prominent in this scene.

- Yoseph is reunited with his brother Binyamin, who is his inverted doppelganger in this moment—Binyamin the beloved son has been brought down to Egypt by the brothers who are carrying money they believe doesn’t belong to them.
- But the presence of Binyamin with the money shows that the brothers have truly changed since Genesis 37. They now have two-times the money, and could easily abandon father and brother and run

away with the cash. But instead, they have safely delivered both brother and money out of devotion to their father.

- The brothers' bowing down means much more than the first time in [Genesis 42:6](#). It provides a second fulfillment of Yoseph's dreams in [Genesis 37:7-10](#), but it does more given the intervening narrative. Now the brothers' bowing is before not just Yoseph as their authority, but as their merciful brother who is coming to know that they also fear God as he does.
- The meal scene recalls the multiple "reconciliation over meals" design patterns; when brothers make peace they often "eat and drink" together (Isaac and Abimelech in [Gen. 26:30](#), Yaaqov and Laban in [Gen. 31:46, 54](#)).
- This scene also reverses the betrayal in Genesis 37, when the brothers threw Yoseph into the pit, "they sat down to eat bread" ([לֹאכַל לֶחֶם](#), [Gen. 37:24](#)). So now in this moment of potential reconciliation, they sit down to eat bread ([Gen. 43:31](#)), BUT they are sitting separately, which becomes a physical image of their relational separation.

Elements in this scene also highlight the remaining disunity among the brothers. The seating scene highlights multiple remaining rifts in the relationship in increasing stages.

- In [Genesis 43:32](#), Yoseph and his brothers and the Egyptians (sons of Ham) cannot yet sit together (notice how the rift between the sons of Ham and Shem are set in relationship to the rift between the sons of Rachel and Leah).
- In [Genesis 43:33](#), The brothers are arranged according to their "rival" birth positions: recalling Reuven's power grab from Yaaqov in [Genesis 35:22](#), and Shimon and Levi's treachery in [chapter 34](#).
- In [Genesis 43:34](#), Binyamin is favored over his brothers, which recalls Yaaqov's favor of Yoseph.

This is all part of Yoseph's test!

- After restoring Shimon to the brothers ([Gen. 43:23](#)), Yoseph has all the brothers together, and this meal of reconciliation becomes one more stage to the test as he recreates the scene from [Genesis 37](#).
- Yoseph seats the brothers according to birth order, which brings to mind the unfair elevation of Yoseph that generated their rivalry in the first place. From Reuven down to Binyamin, each is sat according to their rank, which would highlight Binyamin's low status in the family.
- But then, Yoseph brilliantly gives Binyamin five times more food than any of the other brothers! Yoseph is treating Binyamin with extravagant favor, just as Yaaqov treated him. Yoseph's coat of colors is matched by Binyamin's five portions!
- Yoseph's goal is to recreate the conditions of [Genesis 37](#), to see if the brothers are going to treat Binyamin, the beloved son of Yaaqov, the way that they treated him.

Yoseph the Righteous Snake-Tester

44:1 And he commanded the one over his house, saying,
"Fill **the sacks** of the men with food,
as much as they are able to carry.
And set **the silver** of each in **the mouth of his sack**.
2 And **my goblet, the goblet** of silver,

you will set in **the mouth of the sack** of **the little one** ,
and **the silver** of his trade-grain.”
And he did **according to the word** that Yoseph spoke.

³ At the morning light,
the men were sent out, they and **their donkeys**.

⁴ **As they went out of the city**,
they had not gone far,
then Yoseph said to the one over his house,
“Get up, chase after the men,
and overtake them and say to them,
‘Why have to repaid evil in the place of good?!
⁵ Isn’t **this** what my master uses to drink?
And doesn’t he **perform divination with it** ?
You have done evil by doing this!’”

⁶ **And he overtook them**,
and **he spoke to them these words** ,

⁷ **and they said** to him,
a “Why does my master **speak words** like these?!
Far be it from **your servants** to do a thing like this!
b ⁸ Look, **the silver** that we found in **the mouth of our sacks**,
we returned it to you from the land of Cana’an,
so how could we steal from the house of our master, **silver or gold** ?
a’ ⁹ **The one** among **your servants** with whom **it is found**, he must die,
and as for us, **we will become your servants** .”

¹⁰ **And he said** ,
“So now, **according to your words** , so it will be.
The one with whom **it is found** **will become my servant** ,
and y’all will be innocent.”

¹¹ And they each quickly got down **his sack** , onto the ground,
and each opened up **his sack** ,

¹² **and he searched**, starting with **the biggest** and finishing with **the smallest** ,
and he found the goblet **in the sack** of **Binyamin**.

¹³ And they tore their garments,
and each burdened upon **his donkey** ,
and they returned to the city.

Yoseph brings his test of the brothers to its climax.

- The scene is framed by Yoseph's filling of the sacks, placing the cup, and the brothers leaving the city, matched by their opening the sacks, finding the cup, and going back to the city.
- Yoseph replays his first test, of giving them their silver in return ([ch. 42](#)), but now the stakes are higher, with the silver cup in Binyamin's bag. If the brothers resisted the temptation to take off with the double money in chapter 42, now they are in a position to take double the money and be rid of their brother. After Yoseph's attempt to arouse the brothers' jealousy by giving the extra portions to Binyamin, he now provides them with an attempt to ditch their favored younger brother.
- Notice also how the brothers' suggestion is countered by Yoseph's servant, precisely in order to provide the brothers with the perfect chance to abandon Binyamin and take off with the money.

The Brothers' Suggestion	The Servant's Restatement
(1) With whomever it is found	Now let it also be according to your words, (1) with whomever it is found
(2) among your servants, let him die,	(2) shall be my servant,
(3) and we also will be my lord's slaves.	(3) and y'all shall be innocent.
<i>Brothers' Suggestion Versus Servant's Restatement.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

The focus on the "silver goblet" is curious, along with the apparently random statement of Yoseph that he uses the goblet to perform divination. This phrase is very intentional, however, as it forms a hyperlink to two earlier stories.

- Yaaqov's flight from Laban
- Rachel's theft of the idols

Genesis 44	Genesis 30-31
Gen. 44:4 "Go, chase after (רדף אחרי) the men and overtake them (נשג)"	Gen. 31:23 Laban "took his brothers and chased after (רדף אחרי) him ... and overtook (דבק) him in the hills"
Gen. 44:4 "Why have you repaid good with	Gen. 31:24 God to Laban: "Be careful that you
<i>Comparing Genesis 44 and Genesis 30-31.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Genesis 44	Genesis 30-31
bad/evil?"	don't speak to Yaaqov good or bad."
Gen. 44:5 "Doesn't [Yoseph] perform divination (נחש) with this cup?"	Gen. 30:27 Laban: "I have learned by divination (נחש) that Yahweh has blessed me on account of you."
Gen. 44:2 The cup is placed in the saddle-bag of Binyamin, son of Rachel	Gen. 31:19, 34 Rachel stole the household idols that belong to her father and placed them in the camel's saddle-bag
Gen. 44:12 Yoseph's servant "searches" (חפש) for the cup, starting with the oldest and ending with the youngest, finding (מצא) the cup in Binyamin's sack	Gen. 31:33-34 Laban searches through the tents for his idols, starting with the oldest Leah, ending with the youngest Rachel, finding (מצא) nothing.
Gen. 44:5 "You all have done a bad thing by doing this!"	Gen. 31:26 "What have you done, by deceiving me?"
Gen. 44:9 "The one with whom it is found, that one will die."	Gen. 31:32 "The one with whom you find your idol-gods, that one will not live."
<i>Comparing Genesis 44 and Genesis 30-31. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

These parallels clearly establish an analogy between Yaaqov and Rachel's deception of Laban and the staged "deception" of the brothers against Yoseph. This parallel, however, only highlights the ironic reversals at work.

- In reality, it is Yoseph who is counter-deceiving his brothers for their original betrayal and deception against him and Yaaqov.
- This is another example of the children replaying and intensifying the failures of their parents, in ways that twist and invert the original evil.

Yehudah Surrenders His Life for Binyamin

¹⁴ **And Yehudah came**, and his brothers, into the house of Yoseph, and he was still there, and he fell before him on the ground.

Yoseph Speaks

- ¹⁵ And Yoseph said to them,
A "What is **this thing that you have done** ?!
Don't you know that a man like me **performs divination** ?"

Yehudah Speaks

- ¹⁶ And Yehudah said,
" **What can** we say to **my master** ?
What can we speak?
B **What can** we do to prove ourselves right?
Elohim **has found** out the iniquity of **your servants** .
Look, we are **servants** for **my master** ,
Both us, and **the one with whom** **the goblet** **was found** **in his hand.**"

Yoseph Speaks

- ¹⁷ And he said,
A' "Far be it from me **to do such a thing** !
The man with whom **the goblet** **was found** **in his hand**,
that one will become **my servant** .
And you all can go up in peace to your father."

- ¹⁸ **And Yehudah drew near** ,
and he said,
"Please **my master** ,
let **your servant** speak, please, a word in the ears of **my master** ,
and don't let your anger burn hot against **your servant** ,
because you are like Phar'oh."

Genesis 44:14-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

- ¹⁹ " **My master** asked **his servants** , saying,
'Do you have a **father** or **brother** ?'
²⁰ And we said to **my master** ,
'We do have a **father**, **an old one** ,
and **a child** of his old age, **a little one** .
And **his brother** is dead,
and he alone remains of **his mother** ,
and **his father** loves him.'

21 And you said to **your servants** ,
'**Bring him down** to me,
so I can set my eyes upon him.'

22 And we said to **my master** ,
'The **boy** is not able to leave **his father**.
If he leaves, **his father** will die.'

23 And you said to **your servants** ,
'If **your brother** , **the little one** , does not **come down** with you,
you will not again see my face.'

Genesis 44:19-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

A 24 "And it came about, when **we went up** to **your servant** , **my father** ,
that **we told him** the words of **my master** ,

B 25 and **our father said to us** ,
'Return, and buy grain for us, a little food.'

26 **And we said** ,
'**We** are not able to **go down** .
A' If **our brother** , **the little one** , is with us, then we will go down,
because we are not able to see the face of the man,
if **our brother** , **the little one** , is not with us.'

27 And **your servant** , **our father** , said to us,
'You all know that my wife bore for me **two** ,
28 and **the one** went out from me,
and I said,
"Indeed, he has been torn apart!"
And I have not seen him even until now.
29 And you would take also **this one** from before my face?!
Disaster will happen to him!
And then **you will make my gray hair go down in evil to the grave!**'

30 So now, when I go to **your servant** , **my father** ,
and **the boy** is not with us,
his very being is bound together with his very being,
A 31 and when he sees that **the boy** is not with us, **then he will die** ,
and **your servants** **would make the gray hair** of **your servant** , **our father** ,

go down to the grave in grief.

32 Surely, **your servant** has given himself as **a down-payment** for **the boy** with **my father**,
B saying,
'If I do not bring him to you,
it will be my sin against **my father** all of my days.'

33 So now, let **your servant** please sit **in the place of** **the boy** as **a servant** to **my master**,
and **the boy**, let him **go up** with his brothers,
A' 34 because how can I **go up** to **my father**,
and **the boy** is not with me?
So I don't have to see **the evil that would find** **my father**!"

Genesis 44:24-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yehudah's Speech: A Rhetorical Masterpiece

The scene begins and ends with the brothers standing before Yoseph ([Gen. 44:14](#) and [45:1](#)), and the macro-design displays a two-step dialogue between Yoseph and Yehudah. Yoseph's two speeches focus on the stolen cup and the consequence of taking Binyamin as a slave. Yehudah's two responses are paired through the way he and the brothers show complete solidarity with their younger brother Binyamin.

Yehudah's two speeches respond to Yoseph's words in step. In [Genesis 44:16](#), Yehudah reframes the terms of Yoseph's servant by saying that all of the brothers will be enslaved along with Binyamin. Once Yoseph denies this possibility, Yehudah steps up and offers just himself.

Yehudah's speech begins with an opening plea to hear ([Gen. 44:18](#)), and then falls into two parts.

1. Part 1: [Genesis 44:19-28](#) recounts the basic narrative of [chapters 42-43](#) as a series of dialogues between Yoseph and the brothers ([Gen. 44:19-23](#)), and then between the brothers and Yaaqov ([Gen. 44:24-29](#)). Notice how the framing sections focus on Yaaqov's two beloved sons with Rachel, so that Binyamin and Yoseph's death are mentioned in just [Genesis 44:19-20](#) and in [Genesis 44:27-29](#).
 - Inside of that frame, Yehudah presents the brothers as stuck between two impossible expectations: Yoseph said it was impossible to see him or to get food without Binyamin ([Gen. 44:21-23](#)), while Yaaqov made it impossible to take Binyamin to Egypt ([Gen. 44:24-26](#)). This portrays the real tension as taking place between Yoseph and Yaaqov, and paints the brothers as helpless messengers.
2. Part 2: The second half of Yehudah's speech in [Genesis 44:30-34](#) plays to Yoseph's empathy for an old man. In the first and last statements, Yehudah says that if the brothers return to Yaaqov without Binyamin, it will kill their aging father ([Gen. 44:30-31](#) and [44:34](#)). Inside this movement are two paired statements about Yehudah's willingness to give his life in the place of Binyamin's. This is the climax of the speech, and it represents a stunning character development in Yehudah.
 - In [Genesis 44:32](#), Yehudah recounts how he offered himself as a pledge for Binyamin and how leaving Binyamin behind would be an eternal sin against his father.

- In Genesis 44:33, Yehudah turns his past pledge to Yaaqov into a present plea to Yoseph as he offers himself “in the place of” his brother. This is precisely what Yehudah did not do in chapter 37, when he tried to profit off the slavery of the beloved son Yoseph. In this moment, Yehudah reverses his past failure and redeems his compromised character.

Yehudah Becomes Adam and Eve and Cain

This exchange between the two brothers Yoseph and Yehudah is packed with verbal links to earlier narratives that carry on the analogies with Genesis 3-4 that began earlier.

Yoseph is portrayed as Elohim, who tests Adam and Eve and shows up asking Cain what he has done.

Genesis 44	Genesis 3-4
Gen. 44:15 Yoseph: “Don’t you know that a man like me performs divination (נחש ינחש)?”	Gen. 3:1 “Now, the snake (נחש) was shrewd, more than any beast of the field.”
Gen. 44:15 “What is this thing that you have done?!”	Gen. 3:13 Yahweh to Eve: “What is this thing that you have done?” Gen. 4:10 Yahweh to Cain: “What have you done?”
Gen. 44:16 “Elohim has found out (מצא) the iniquity (עון) of your servants.”	Gen. 4:13-14 Cain to Yahweh: “My iniquity (עון) is too great to bear ... anyone who finds (מצא) will kill me.”
Gen. 44:18 Yehudah to Yoseph: “Don’t let your anger burn hot against your servant.”	Gen. 4:6 Yahweh to Cain: “Why does your anger burn hot?”
<i>Repeated Language in Genesis 44 and Genesis 3-4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph’s confrontation with his brothers is compared here to God coming to Adam and Eve and Cain immediately after their acts of folly and evil (and recall that Gen. 3-4 first set up the analogy between parents and children).

The snake/cup turns out to be an instrument of testing the faithfulness of the chosen ones.

Binyamin and Yehudah, the Son and the Substitute

Yehudah’s speech culminates a large-scale design pattern that has been at work since Genesis 37. Since the beginning of the story of Yoseph and his brothers, the narrator has been showing how the two sons of the beloved Rachel are parallel to Yaaqov, Isaac, and Abel.

Parallels With Abel

Abel is the younger son who is murdered by his older brother because he's filled with jealousy and anger at Yahweh's favor on his offering. // Binyamin is the younger brother of Yoseph, who is sold as a slave and virtually "murdered" by his jealous and angry older brothers.

The deceased Abel is replaced with Seth, who is born "in the place of" (תחת) his brother Abel (see Gen. 4:25-26). // Binyamin is replaced by Yehudah, who offers himself "in the place of" (תחת) Binyamin.

Parallels With Yaaqov

Binyamin is, along with Yoseph, a beloved son of Yaaqov's beloved wife Rachel. // Yaaqov is the beloved son of Rebekah. Binyamin is the last remaining son of Rachel, and he is not allowed to leave the land because of his brothers' treachery that involved a deceptive goat-skin designed to trick their father (Gen. 37). // Yaaqov is the beloved son of Rebekah, and he is forced to leave the land because of his treachery that involved a deceptive goat-skin designed to trick his father (Gen. 27).

Binyamin is finally made to go into exile where he and his brothers are tested with a "stolen" cup of divination hidden in the camel bags. // Yaakov goes into exile and eventually is tested with "stolen" idol-gods for divination that are hidden in camel bags.

Binyamin is restored to his father once his older brother Yehudah offers himself as a substitute. // Yaaqov is restored to his father after he offers his own life in the place of his wives and children (Gen. 32).

Parallels With Isaac

Isaac was a miraculous son born to an infertile Sarah. // Yoseph and Binyamin were miraculous sons born to an infertile Rachel.

Isaac was the beloved and favored secondborn son of Abraham. // Yoseph and Binyamin were the beloved and favored sons of the beloved and favored Rachel who was the secondborn herself.

Abraham and Sarah wronged and abused Hagar and Ishmael in their efforts to produce a son. // Yaaqov wronged Leah because of his love for Rachel.

God tested Abraham by demanding that he give up the life of the beloved son, often called "the boy" (הנער) as an offering. // Yaakov is double-tested as he loses the life of Yoseph (which involved a substitute animal death), and then he is forced to surrender the life of Binyamin (also called "the boy" הנער).

At the last moment, God provides a substitute for Isaac in the form of a ram offered in the place of the beloved son. // At the last moment, Yehudah offers himself as a substitute in the place of the beloved son.

Abraham's surrender of Isaac opens up God's covenant blessing for all the nations. // Yehudah's surrender of his own life opens up reconciliation, abundant food, security, and life for Yaaqov's family.

Conclusion

These portraits of Binyamin, Yehudah, and Yoseph bring the themes of Genesis 1-3 to their culmination. The promise of the seed of the woman in Genesis 3:15, who is at odds with the snake and those who give in to its lies, has led to a clash of siblings and the death or exile of a child in every generation. In each case, it is only

after a chosen son gives up their life and is replaced by a sacrificial substitute that the story of God's purposes moves forward.

This is the precisely the same theme we see surfacing in the Prophets of the Hebrew Bible. God plans to raise up a suffering servant who is a royal-prophet-priest, who will stand up to rebellious Israel, only to be rejected and killed as a substitute, leading to victory and rule over Israel and the nations. This is what Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the scroll of the twelve are all about!

Reflection Question

Reflect on the ways that Yoseph and Yehudah each represent different aspects of the same theme: the chosen son who must offer himself as a substitute for others.